

THE MALVERN HILLS

After spending a short period of time in London soon after their marriage, the Elgars returned to live near the Malvern Hills in rural Worcestershire, where they had both been born and brought up. The countryside remained a source of immense comfort, joy, and inspiration to Elgar throughout his life.

Criticism and acclaim

Elgar's finest choral work, *The Dream of Gerontius*, followed, but did not win easy acceptance. With a setting of a long poem by Cardinal John Henry Newman, the key figure in the Catholic revival in 19th-century England, it provoked criticism from the Protestant Church. Its first performance at the Birmingham Festival in 1900 was a poorly rehearsed shambles that reduced the composer to despair. However, the following year his stirring *Pomp and Circumstance* marches were greeted with frantic enthusiasm by patriotic audiences. The first of them soon became an unofficial national anthem, the well-known melody of the trio section later acquiring lyrics as "Land of Hope and Glory." In 1902, *Gerontius* was performed to acclaim in Germany, and the English now realized that, for the first time since the 17th century, they had a native-born composer of international stature.

Elgar was fêted and showered with honors, culminating in a knighthood in 1904. He bought a large house in Hereford and acquired wealthy friends, concealing his neurotic, sensitive, melancholy nature behind the persona of a bluff, dog-loving, golf-playing English gentleman. Adopted by the British establishment, he always at heart felt like an outsider, because of